1947. While Indian defences at Uri held back repeated attacks, the fall of Jhangar on 24 December was a major setback for India. Thereafter, two additional battalions – 1 GRENADIERS from Delhi and 2 PARA from East Punjab Command – were sent to bases at Uri and Poonch respectively, tasked with protecting the Indian Army's precarious lines of communication and defending the routes to Srinagar and Jammu.



On 27 October 1947, 1 SIKH landed at Srinagar, after Maharaja Hari Singh, ruler of Kashmir, had signed the instrument of accession the day before. The battalion was flown in by three Douglas Dakota transports of No. 12 Squadron RIAF. The Pakistani invaders were just 35km away from Srinagar when the first Dakota landed. (Bettmann/Getty Images)

In February 1948, the militias launched Operation *Hammer* with the aim of taking Skardu, Kargil and then Leh. Initially held by an Indian Army platoon, Leh was reinforced by 40 volunteers who crossed the Zojila Pass. Using the volunteers' extra rifles, a local militia was raised and armed for the defence of Leh. As Indian troop numbers increased, the Pakistan Army